

Psychology Expert Validation Feedback

Doomscrolling Detection and Digital Mindfulness Mobile Application for Short-Form Video Platforms

Reviewer's General Impression

After reviewing the submitted scoping brief and validation compilation, the proposed application appears to have a strong foundation as a non-clinical digital wellness tool intended to help users become more aware of prolonged and potentially unhealthy scrolling behavior.

The project clearly avoids presenting itself as a psychological assessment or mental health treatment application, which is an important ethical consideration. The overall structure of the interventions, the use of behavioral indicators, and the privacy-focused design are generally appropriate for an undergraduate research project.

At the same time, there are several areas where adjustments in wording, framing, and intervention intensity would help reduce the possibility of users misunderstanding the system as a clinical or diagnostic tool.

Validation Findings

1. Intervention Structure and Psychological Appropriateness

The three-level intervention system (Awareness Notification → Pause Prompt → Breathing Overlay) is psychologically reasonable as a digital mindfulness strategy.

The gradual escalation works well because it starts with low-intensity reminders before moving into more noticeable interruptions. This approach helps avoid overwhelming users while still encouraging reflection on their scrolling habits.

One of the strengths of the design is that the system does not force users to stop using the application. Instead, it encourages self-awareness and gives users the ability to decide what to do next. From a psychological perspective, preserving user autonomy is important because overly controlling interventions may lead to resistance or frustration.

Recommendation

The interventions should continue to use supportive and neutral language. The prompts should feel like reminders or wellness nudges rather than warnings about problematic behavior.

2. Use of the Doomscrolling Feedback Loop Model

The Doomscrolling Feedback Loop Model is an appropriate theoretical basis for the application.

The system appropriately limits itself to observable behavior such as:

- session duration,
- dwell time,
- and exposure to negative content.

Importantly, the application does not claim to measure emotional states, psychological distress, or psychiatric conditions directly. This distinction is clearly stated throughout the documentation and should remain heavily emphasized in the final implementation.

The current framing of the system as a behavioral estimation and self-monitoring tool is psychologically appropriate.

Recommendation

The researchers should consistently remind users that:

- the app only estimates scrolling patterns,
- the scores are heuristic rather than diagnostic,
- and the application is not intended to evaluate mental health status.

This clarification should appear:

- during onboarding,
- in the settings page,
- and near the dashboard or score displays.

3. Evaluation of the Fuzzy Logic Rule Base

The overall logic behind the 27-rule fuzzy inference system is conceptually acceptable for a non-clinical application.

The prioritization of prolonged exposure and high negative-content engagement makes psychological sense within the context of doomscrolling behavior.

The decision to treat dwell time as a supporting factor rather than the main indicator is also reasonable. Spending a long time on a single piece of content does not automatically indicate unhealthy engagement.

The rule structure generally demonstrates:

- logical escalation,
- consistency,
- and reasonable behavioral interpretation.

Concern Regarding Rule 25

Rule 25 classifies:

- High Dwell Time,
- High Negative Sentiment Density,
- and Low Session Duration
as “Critical.”

This classification may be too strong for a short session.

A user may briefly engage with emotionally heavy content without necessarily demonstrating problematic or compulsive scrolling behavior. Labeling this as “Critical” could potentially feel exaggerated or alarming.

Recommendation

It may be more proportionate to classify this condition under a Warning-level response instead of triggering the strongest intervention.

This adjustment may help reduce unnecessary user anxiety and improve trust in the application.

4. Timing and Prompt Frequency

The 15-minute threshold before interventions begin is psychologically reasonable and supported by the literature cited in the compilation.

The threshold appears balanced enough to:

- avoid excessive interruption,
- reduce prompt fatigue,

- and still capture sustained scrolling behavior.

Similarly, the 15-minute cooldown period between prompts is appropriate for reducing user burden.

Recommendation

Future versions of the application may benefit from:

- adjustable sensitivity settings,
- personalized thresholds,
- or adaptive timing based on user preference.

Giving users more control may improve long-term acceptance and reduce feelings of surveillance.

5. Review of the User-Facing Prompts

Level 1 — Awareness Notification

The Level 1 notification is appropriately lightweight and minimally intrusive.

This type of intervention is suitable for increasing awareness without immediately disrupting user activity.

Recommendation

The wording should remain calm, neutral, and non-judgmental.

Examples of appropriate wording include:

- “You’ve been scrolling for a while.”
- “Consider taking a short break.”
- “You may want to pause and reset.”

The following types of wording should be avoided:

- “Warning”
- “Risk detected”
- “You are doomscrolling”
- “Critical behavior detected”

These phrases may create shame, defensiveness, or anxiety.

Level 2 — Pause Prompt

The Level 2 modal is psychologically appropriate because it introduces friction while still preserving user choice.

Allowing users to:

- continue,
- take a break,
- or view their usage statistics
helps maintain autonomy.

Recommendation

The interface should avoid visually favoring one option over another. The design should feel supportive rather than coercive.

Level 3 — Breathing Overlay

The breathing overlay is understandable as a behavioral interruption strategy; however, this is the part of the system most likely to be interpreted as a mental health intervention.

Breathing exercises are commonly associated with stress reduction and emotional regulation. Because of this, users may assume the application is providing therapeutic support even if the researchers do not intend it that way.

Recommendations

1. Reframe the feature using non-clinical language such as:
 - “Pause and Reset”
 - “Take a Short Breathing Break”
instead of “Breathing Intervention.”
2. Include a brief disclaimer stating that the feature is intended only as a digital wellness pause and not as treatment.

3. Allow users to:
 - skip the activity,
 - shorten the duration,
 - or disable this feature.
4. A shorter default duration of around 30–45 seconds may better support the non-clinical framing.

6. Risk of Harm and Ethical Considerations

One of the main psychological concerns involves the use of terms such as:

- “Risk”
- “Warning”
- “Critical”
- and “Detection.”

Although these terms are understandable from a systems-design perspective, they may unintentionally sound clinical or diagnostic to users.

Some users may interpret the application as evaluating their mental health or emotional stability.

Possible unintended effects include:

- anxiety about scrolling behavior,
- excessive self-monitoring,
- guilt or shame,
- and frustration toward the app.

Recommendation

Softer and more neutral terminology would likely reduce these risks.

Suggested alternatives:

Current Term	Suggested Alternative
Risk Score	Activity Pattern Score
Warning	Elevated Use
Critical	Extended Exposure
Detection	Pattern Monitoring

Recommended Safeguards

The application should include:

- clear non-clinical disclaimers,
- opt-out settings,
- adjustable notifications,
- intervention controls,
- and mental health referral information.

An example disclaimer may state:

“This application is intended only for digital wellness and self-monitoring. It does not diagnose, treat, or assess mental health conditions.”

7. Cultural Considerations for Filipino Users

The interventions appear generally appropriate for Filipino adult users.

The non-confrontational and reflective style of the prompts fits well with communication styles that are typically more indirect and socially sensitive.

However, there may be limitations in the sentiment analysis system when interpreting:

- sarcasm,
- humor,
- slang,
- Taglish expressions,
- and culturally specific emotional language.

Recommendation

The researchers should acknowledge that sentiment interpretation may not always accurately capture emotional tone within Filipino online communication contexts.

This limitation should be included in the study discussion.

8. Evaluation Methodology

The two-week field deployment is acceptable for:

- usability testing,
- feasibility evaluation,
- and short-term behavioral observation.

However, the duration is not sufficient to support conclusions regarding:

- long-term habit change,
- sustained psychological effects,
- or behavioral dependence reduction.

The thesis appropriately acknowledges these limitations.

Recommendation

If feasible, the addition of a short mindfulness or emotional well-being measure may strengthen the psychological interpretation of the findings without significantly increasing participant burden.

Final Validation Conclusion

Overall, the proposed application is psychologically defensible as a non-clinical digital wellness and behavioral awareness tool.

The strongest aspects of the project include:

- privacy-conscious design,
- transparent limitations,
- adaptive intervention structure,
- and careful avoidance of direct mental health claims.

The application is most appropriate when framed as:

- a reflective self-monitoring tool,
- a digital wellness support application,
- and a behavioral interruption system.

The project should avoid language or presentation styles that resemble:

- diagnosis,
- mental health screening,
- or psychological treatment.

With revisions to terminology, additional safeguards, and softer intervention framing, the system is suitable for pilot testing and undergraduate thesis implementation among Filipino adult users.

Overall Assessment

Conceptual Foundation

Acceptable with minor revisions.

Intervention Design

Psychologically appropriate for non-clinical use.

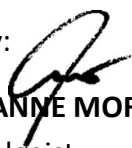
Ethical Framing

Needs softer terminology and stronger disclaimers.

Risk Management

Adequate, though additional user controls are recommended.

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